

Source Translation Ledger

The Poems, With RICD's Mathematics Set Directly Above the Lines It Describes

Math is set in blue italics directly above the line or passage it corresponds to. Reflects RICD version 11.3.

The Next Time

$O_o(t)$ corrupted by developmental entropic damage while $O_p(t)$ remains comparatively intact -- the baseline condition for most living systems, humans particularly (Definitions 10.5b.2.12-13). Baseline Miscalibration (Definition 10.5b.2.20): destabilizing signal read as calm, restrictive coupling read as protective.

The next time we
go stumbling through
bright woods
in search of darkness,

$a(t)$, adaptive capacity -- sacrificed pre-maturity rather than developed.

the next time we
hold our breath
and shear our
paper wings off,

$X_{\{i,j\}}$, extraction flux (§8.6a) -- the target/extractor relationship. Baseline Miscalibration: damaging exchange read as rewarding.

the next time we trust
the tower guard
with the unblinking eye,

Captive Official Layer (Definition 10.5b.18.1) -- a corrupted O_o sincerely, not deceptively, believing what it is told.

the next time
we believe anything
taught in a world so
fraught it's impossible
to emerge from;

Repetition-Compulsion Drive (Definition 10.5b.2.18) -- the same cycle recurring without the container recognizing it as a cycle.

the next time we brave
this wilderness
with innocence,
unquestioning belief
in the pure motives
of our narrative,
the next time

we mistake our
stumble for our
arrival, the next rescue
will be ours:

Search Cessation (Definition 10.5b.2.21) -- ceasing the search for false security is a real, separate precondition, prior to and distinct from what follows. A_{ij} , real network coupling strength -- mutual, reciprocal stabilization. The semi-rigid horizontal matrix (Shaking Bowls' own term) forming through voluntary affiliation (§10.5b.2.17's Horizontal Matrix Attraction).

in the tears that bind us
to kindness
we'll flounder in
the big bright darkness,
our bright eyes
shining wet
and full of stars.

Rumination

Extraction-Hunger Accumulator (Definition 10.5b.19.1) -- a self-reinforcing reward cycle around extraction, structurally close to addiction.

(It's like scratching an itch
to go down into that darkness).

A prying scratch, prising the light from your eyes, dimming your grin, cracking your teeth,
weathering them to old porcelain.
Some ancient addiction, perhaps,
a rage at being born, at the windmilling
futility of it all.

The medium-entropy system's real vulnerability (Shaking Bowls; Sampling Fidelity Requirement, Definition 10.5b.15.1) -- mistaking a predatory neighbor's momentary stillness for genuine stability.

It's easy to do, too,
because pain we may presume a greater gift than joy
against the ravages of time and space
as it's less fleeting;
love might be the point, but
like a precious gem it's mined near through
and the marketplace is flooded with fakes.

And the ones who hate—
the ones who spend their every waking
moment burning to lash out at any who scrape
the barest happiness out of this circumstance
in order to remind them all the time

how very miserable they really
must be at the mess we've made
of our whole family tree—
well they make life memorable, too.

Epistemic Capture (Definition 10.5b.15.3) -- a medium-entropy system coming to believe the entropic, self-deceiving message IS the true message and the only reality, not merely being drawn toward it.

(Yes, it gets easy after a while
scratching the itch
that pulls us down, down, beneath the skin).

You Get to an Age

Reconciling paradoxical extremes without forcing a false resolution -- Paradoxical Convergence, medium-entropy direction (Definition 10.5b.0.9b): a container ceasing to punish itself for an entropic spike (registering anger, hatred, grief without the accompanying self-suppression response) allows the spike to dissipate through ordinary relaxation rather than compounding into sustained divergence, drifting the container naturally toward its own already-intact operational calm. This is the real mechanism the poem enacts throughout: holding love and rage toward the same person as two genuinely divergent, simultaneously true states, without collapsing either into a forced single verdict.

When you think nothing human
can surprise. That's why I unblocked you, the dead rapist;
such magnanimity, such largesse
of spirit, it swells my chest, presses
against my lungs, flattening speech, flattening breath,
choking me to death, along with those awful
tears that morning I discovered you'd died,
just months after I told you I longed to see you
swinging at the end of your rope.
I'm here because you can still surprise.
Not your political takes, whether those I disagree with,
on the basis of my own humanity (the rhetorical lens
through which you viewed life was misogyny),
or those I agree with, because I am also a struggling teacher,
a struggling writer, just
struggling, saddled with the same
impostor syndrome that you had,
only mine's more learned than earned--
one of the many problems you had with me,
wasn't it? (I was a better version of you
in your mind, and to make matters worse, a woman).
But no. What surprised me is how you managed
to piss me off from beyond the grave.
You were homeless before you died;
even your family didn't have the heart anymore
to help you. --What can I say? What drove them away?

In the end, was it your alcoholism, which really was just your medicine
to forget who you were, for even a second?
Something like that--something that caused them trouble--
something so visibly out of place in the carefully-curated
museum to middle-class values that was their ranch-style home:
I could imagine that finally doing the trick.

Not all the women raped, stalked, strangled in the world
would be enough to make your mother stop smothering
you with her suffocating bond, but you getting too
drunk at family dinner;
well, that's another matter altogether.
What pissed me off is the way you talked
of your life. "As a homeless man with PTSD..."
I suppose van der Kolk, when tallying up the score, spoke
in his book with some sympathy about men like you,
such as the man who couldn't stop shaking after he raped and murdered
a woman during wartime.
Poor guy, I couldn't help but think,
haunted by her ghost, crying out night after night why did you do it.
Maybe some wounds we should have to live with.

Repetition-Compulsion Drive (Definition 10.5b.2.18) -- self-attributed dysfunction generating a bias toward re-engaging the same class of coupling that produced the original disruption.

When I was nineteen, my childhood friend and I
got high with a pair of drug dealers.
I was getting over a relationship with another abuser
of women, this one who liked to strangle, punch, use the same words
his father had used for him when he did the same,
useless, what's the point of you.
I was working full-time after leaving him,
finishing up my degree; he found himself adrift after all the harm
without family to help, a lot like you.
My friend was struggling with addiction, a disease;
I did not know, nor did I know
why we were at that house, just that it started with weed
and progressed to coke, line after line,
and a fight broke out, about, of all things, rape,
which I'd already experienced but couldn't bring myself
to admit, not even to myself.
I played Devil's advocate, arguing I'd rather
be raped than rapist, that even if he
killed you a rapist couldn't touch your soul,
but with that one moment he shattered his own.

They grew angry, telling me, as they gave my friend,
who later almost died, line after line
of the drug that was killing her, that such criminals
should be rounded up, released on an island,
with only each other for company;
I argued that the soul of a rapist is destroyed by his act
worse than he could ever hurt his victim.
They showed us out then, no harm, no foul.
Angry faces, fist bump at the door.
I still remember.
I've had plenty of personal chances to reevaluate;
yet the only thing I got wrong was how much of my soul
a man like you could take.

Self-Corrosion (Definition 10.5b.19.7) -- a closed, high-entropy circuit cannot actually keep what it extracts from another; the attempted extraction itself increases the extractor's own divergence and contracts its own adaptive space, independent of and additional to whatever the extraction did to the target.

Each injection of venom and each attempt to evade it
left me injured, fragmented, strewn across a psychic landscape
more hostile than anyplace on Earth; the war to end
all wars, every bit of evil man can commit, lives in that land,
and the soul, finding itself stranded, flees to whatever foxhole
it can find, sometimes never to be seen again.
I get back fragments, since then; but rapacious, stubborn,
I won't give in. I'm in search of it all, and more;
I want to get something out of this in the end;
or what was it all for, my friend?

When I discovered you died
I cried, because I loved you,
in the beginning. I used to imagine us living in a little house
across from downtown campus, teaching together,
in the early days we knew each other.
All the abstract understanding--of your envy, your insecurity, your personality
disorder, your mental health struggles, your childhood--
will never make me understand
why you set out to destroy someone who loved you;
(or why you weren't the first man nor the last).
It's as if love is some sort of affront,
some violent act, one which deserves a response in kind.
Who knows. Maybe you did get PTSD
from raping, from stalking, from systematically breaking
me down, watching me cry

in your arms, knowing I hated you,
that even up to the day you reached out from the shelter,
all I wanted was you dead.

When I heard you died, I laughed like a maniac.
I laughed all goddamn day and night.
I may be sick as a dog, but here I am, and I'm alive;
10 years later, and which one of us made it?
--Every act shriveled you, didn't it?
You looked like a wizened old man when you died.
Let me go back in time and tell those two young dealers that.

Self-Corrosion (Definition 10.5b.19.7), Proposition 10.5b.19.7.1 (Extraction Is Net-Negative for the Extractor) -- what a closed system takes from another it cannot get back.
In the end what you take from others you can't get back.

Raison d'Être

Ultimate Convergence (Definition 10.5b.0.6) -- dissolution of a rigid container back toward the open, low-entropy baseline.

If there was any reason in at all,
all the violence I've experienced,
if somewhere there is a logic
to the universe,
from atom to Adam,
then it is this, in the end,
not rock bottom
but resurrection.

What's clear is the numbness
I've carried since childhood—a shield
against suffering—can happen
to anyone. And it does,
eventually, too, to nearly
everyone, just to some
very slowly what it did to me all at once, same
fading, same dissolution,

Drift-type versus shock-type classification (Section 9) -- the same real collapse outcome reachable through a slow, homogeneous process or a sudden, discrete one.

but at different speeds—nearly
everyone ends up a ghost.
Whether violence
or the drip-drip-drip erosion
of nothing much happening

it doesn't matter which kills us;

Dissociation Load (Definition 10.5b.18.4c) -- restored, original central dependent variable of the earliest FDFM model.

in an age of iterative screens,
a shrine to dissociation in every bedroom
ghosts argue with ghosts
(the spirit of an angry God's
bad joke—we declare Him dead so He decides
to curse such ingrates by engineering lives
so bereft we forget
every second is precious).

Hull Breach (Section 10.5a) -- verbatim term-level survival. Approach Detectability (Definition 10.5a.1) -- noticeable, fast collapse can more reliably lead to reset than slow, undetected collapse.

In this age, shrieks feel more alive
than sighs; sometimes the hull must breach
for us to sense it, and if there's a reason

Repetition-Compulsion Drive (Definition 10.5b.2.18).

I had to repeat
the many violations of my youth
in my thirties, only worse—(make it
more devastating this time,
someone must have chimed in,
some shiftless staff
writer, armchair director)—
—in hindsight, this was it, wasn't it?
—All this was the gift.—
—They've given me many,
my cleverest hunters,
the men who laid careful traps
as if I were a rare deer,
a delicacy necessary
for the men's survival,
as if my cries ringing out
above birds and brook were not
in fact the downstream consequence
of such men's creature comforts;
—I thank those clever hunters,
who gave so much of themselves
to the hunt,
and I thank too what architects
must exist, for their gifts:
a hard-won insight

into how the light dies in others' eyes,
the first time that it went out
in mine.

Cognitive Dissonance (Definition 10.5b.18.4b) and Dissociation Load (10.5b.18.4c) as the restored causal pathway. Siloing (Definition 10.5b.2.22) and Alienation (Definition 10.5b.2.23) -- network-level disconnection and disconnection from consequence, both now formalized alongside the already-present fragmentation and preference falsification.

—But of all their magnificent gifts—the joy
in suffering, the pained burden
of violence—the price of sickness
remains greatest;
because the only way out of a gray plane
of existence—that place of dead space
and pain, of static
interspliced with blood, of towers
of ever-teetering tasks,
of screams that bury us
where we expected paradise,

Ultimate Convergence / Return to the Plane (Definition 10.5b.0.6) -- and its real counterpart, Forced Flattening (Definition 10.5b.0.9a): genuine convergence cannot be forced into being.

the only way out, back to the sunlit
patch of promise into which
we were born, is
to nearly die, to be resurrected, to become
that being of light born of one's own ashes;

Captive Official Layer (Definition 10.5b.18.1) -- genuine blindness, resolved by real illumination reaching it at last. The 360 reset itself (Definition 10.5b.0.6, Ultimate Convergence; Proposition 10.5b.0.3) -- a direct, self-driven exit from the whole high/medium-entropy dichotomy onto the low-entropy baseline).

—but before all that to be
simply Lazarus, to sink
to the floor to kiss it, on our
knees to shake
with laughter, and so to exit
the cold cave of
our embodiment, blind;—all the old shapes,
those cave shadows, vanish
in one sun-struck blink
of a bleary eye; and
tears fallen, the light
streams in, as we rush to greet
our enemies with a kiss
and then our friends.